

INDEPENDENT ANALYSIS BASED ON PUBLICLY AVAILABLE DATA

Beyond the Cap Hit: NHL Contract Model

Every NHL contract, priced by the model.
For Season 25/26.

WHAT WE WILL COVER

01

The idea

02

The market

03

The model

04

Agency case study

05

Rookies + agency

Valentin Shepelev

shv66@bu.edu | 513 764 4257

Beyond the Cap Hit

Two players can carry the same cap hit.

Does that mean they bring the same value?

01

THE QUESTION

The same money can sit behind very different seasons

Two deals can cost a club identical dollars while the minutes, the role, and the production behind them look nothing alike.

02

THE APPROACH

Price the season first, then compare

The model learns how the league pays for play, role, age, and contract terms, and returns the cap hit it would expect for that player.

03

THE PAYOFF

A shortlist of deals worth a closer look

Where actual and expected drift apart, the contract earns a second read: negotiation prep, comparable deals, or a rookie heading into his next one.

THE IDEA

What's in the analysis

- Three seasons, 23/24 through 25/26
- Every player with at least 10 games in a season
- Scoring, ice time, role, and possession features
- Tracking metrics from NHL Edge
- Contract terms: cap hit, length, years left, rookie status

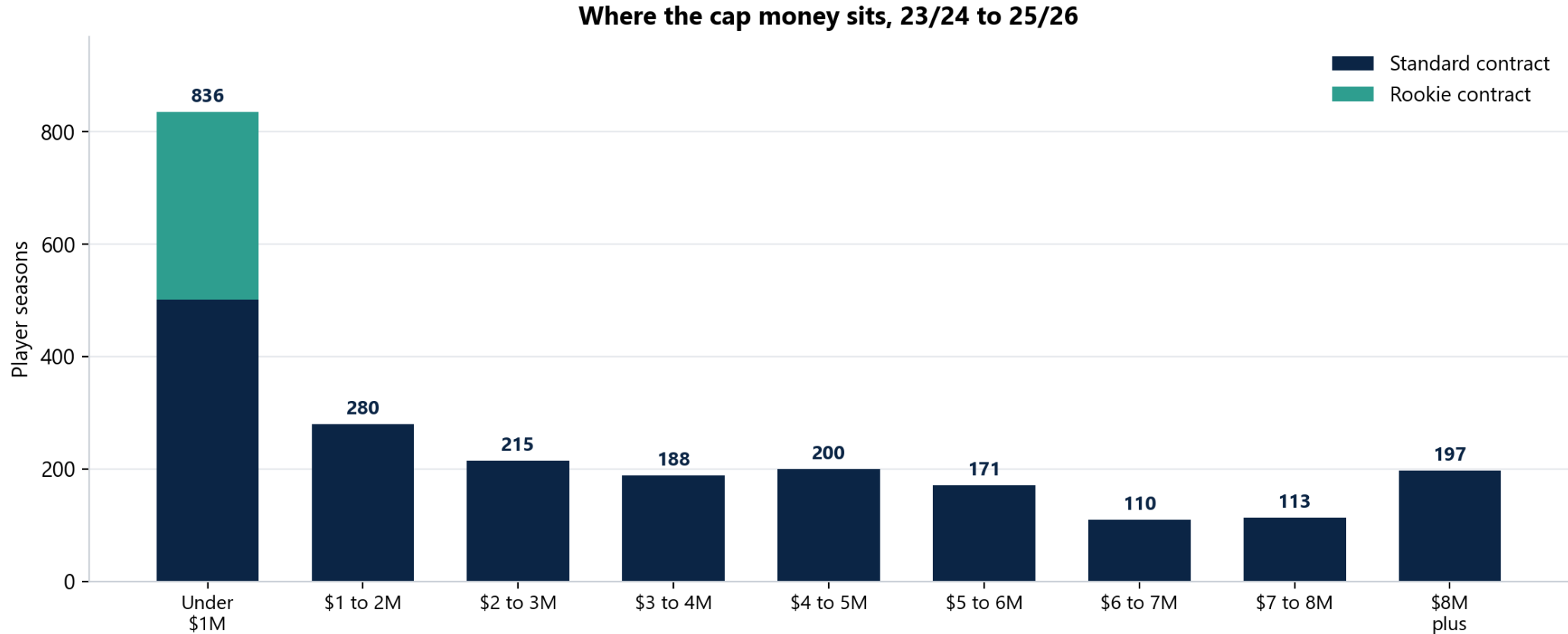
2,310 PLAYER SEASONS

Player	Season	GP	Cap hit
Nathan MacKinnon	23/24	82	\$12.60M
Cale Makar	24/25	80	\$9.00M
Nikita Kucherov	23/24	81	\$9.50M
Nikita Kucherov	24/25	78	\$9.50M
Nikita Kucherov	25/26	76	\$9.50M
Connor McDavid	25/26	82	\$12.50M
Quinn Hughes	25/26	74	\$7.85M

A slice of the table. Kucherov holds 3 rows, one per season.

Cap hit is the contractual hit of the deal, not a retained or mid-season share after a trade.

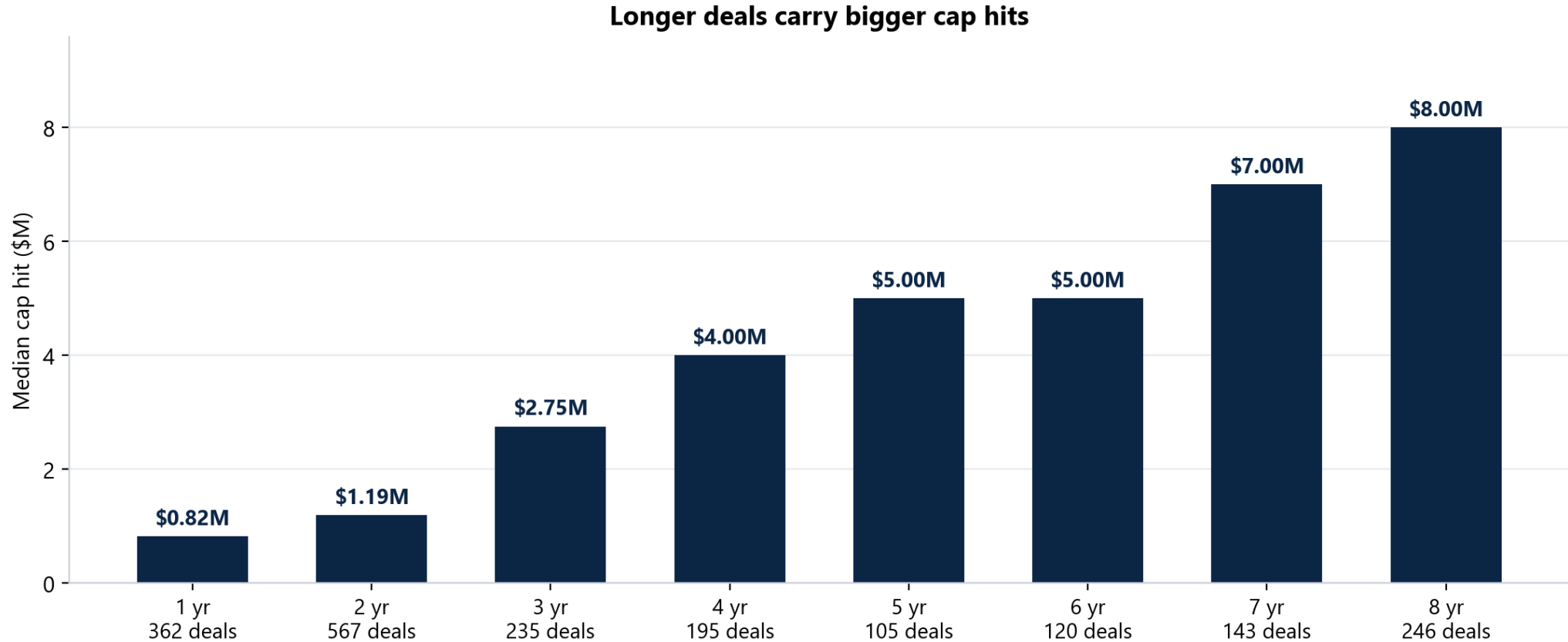
Most of the league is cheap. The top is thin



48% of player seasons sit under \$2M. Only 9% clear \$8M.

Rookie contracts crowd the bottom band, but plenty of standard deals live there too.

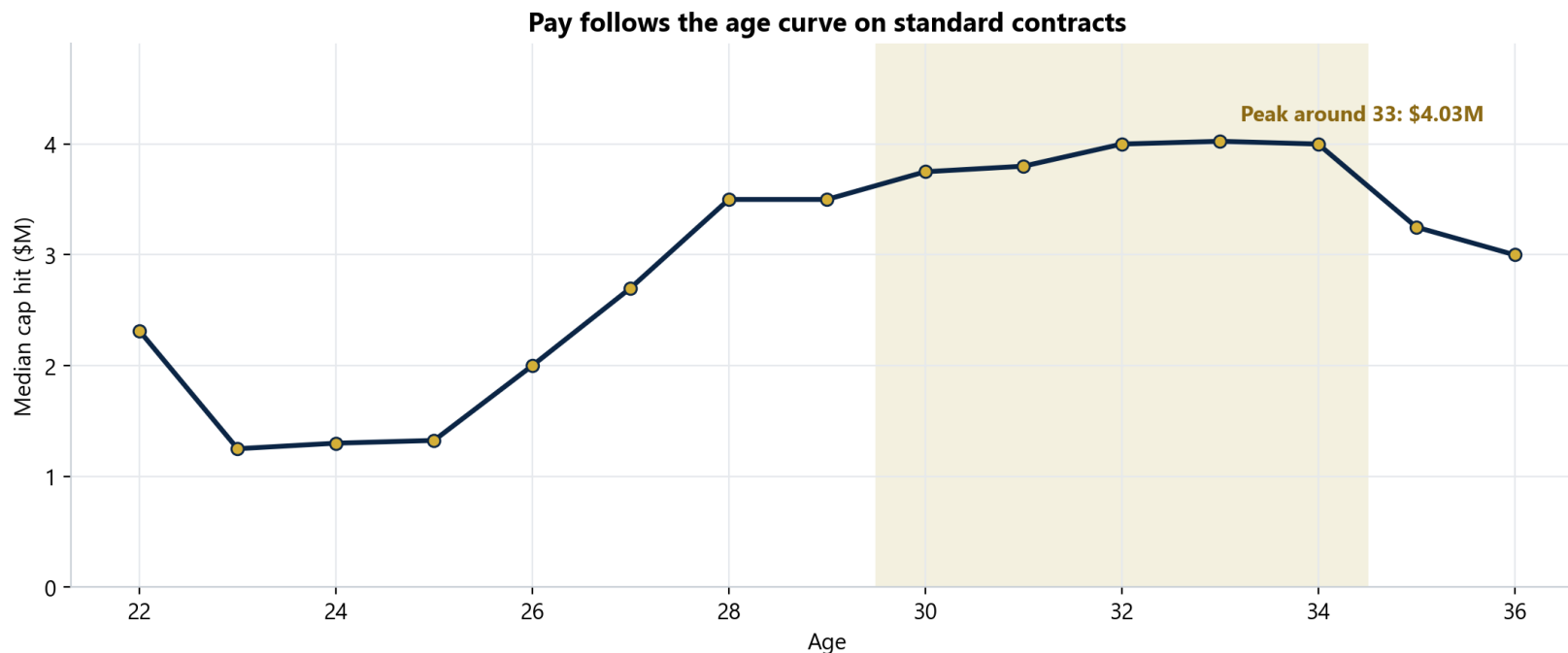
Term and money travel together



Median cap hit climbs from about \$0.8M on one year deals to roughly \$5.0M on five year deals.

Standard contracts only. Short deals are the most common structure in this sample.

Pay follows the age curve



AGE 22

A small pool, mostly players who went straight into a strong second deal.

AGES 23 TO 25

About seven in ten sit on one or two year bridges, which pulls the median down.

PAST 30

Roughly four in ten carry five years or more, at the top of the pay range.

Money peaks in the early thirties, around age 33. Many bridge deals keep the early twenties cheap.

Standard contracts only, ages with at least 20 player seasons.

The model in one screen

- Learns from 23/24 and 24/25, then reads 25/26
- Returns the cap hit it expects a player to carry
- Gap is actual pay minus that expected number

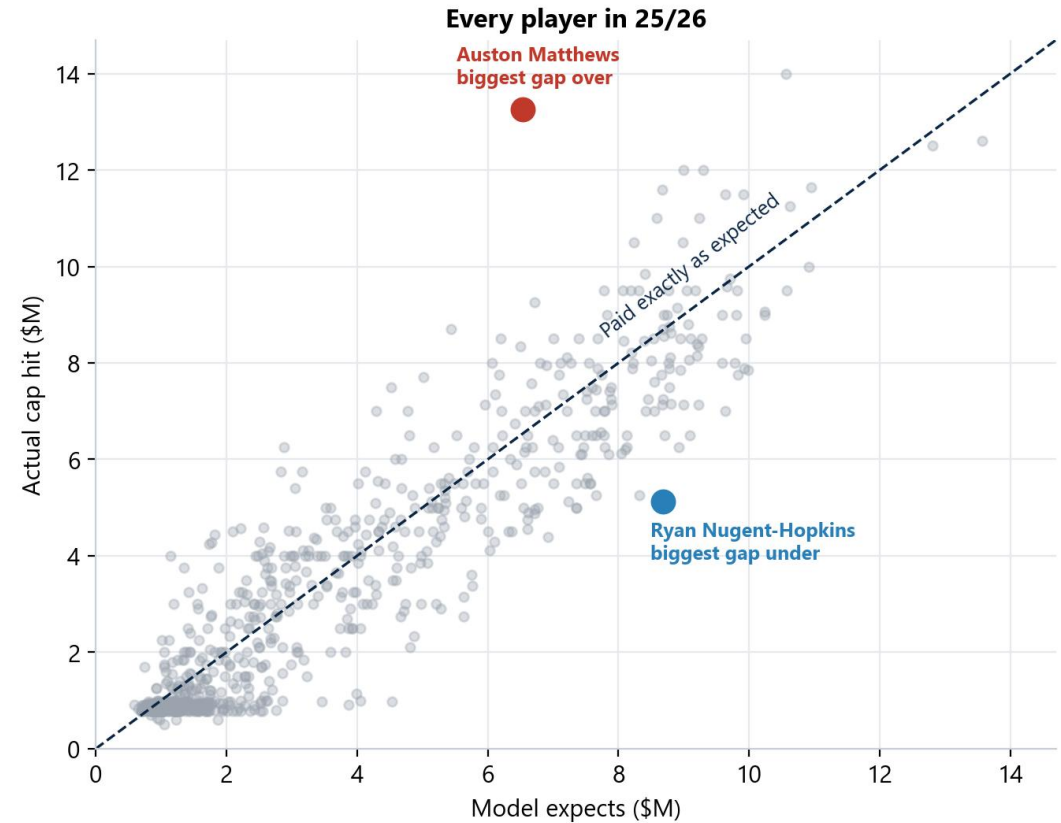
How close it gets

Average miss **\$0.77M**

Inside \$1M **71 of 100**

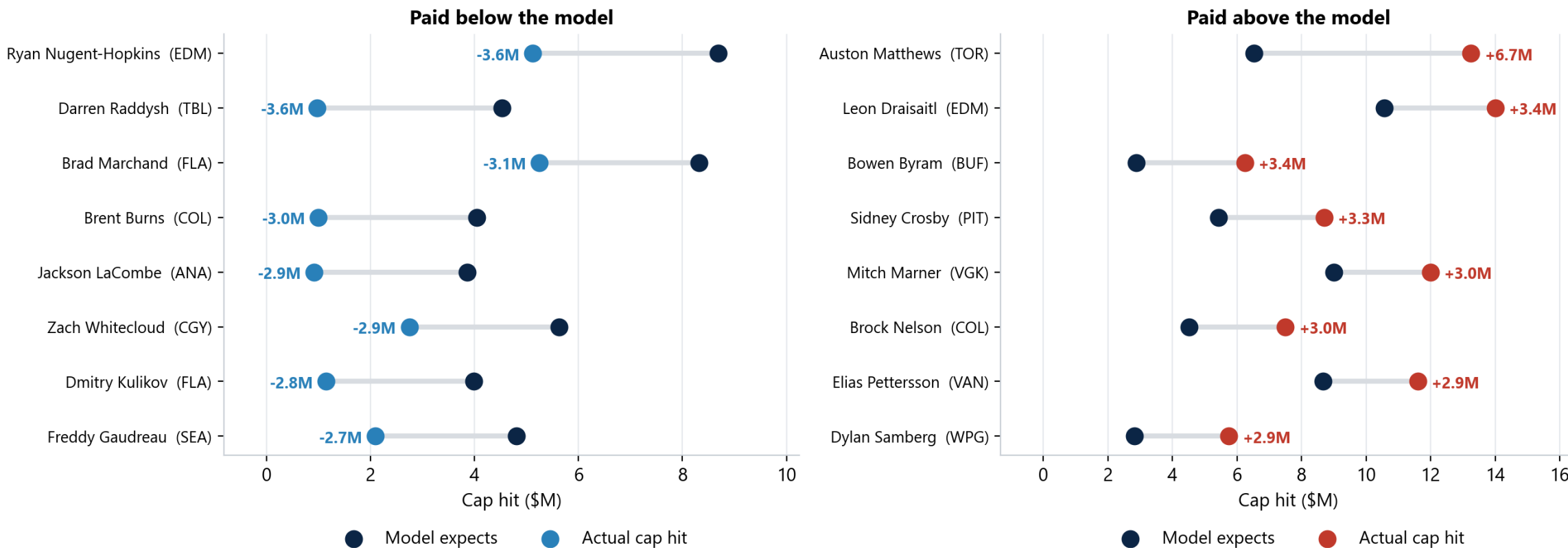
Players checked **778**

Checked against real 25/26 cap hits the model never saw while learning.



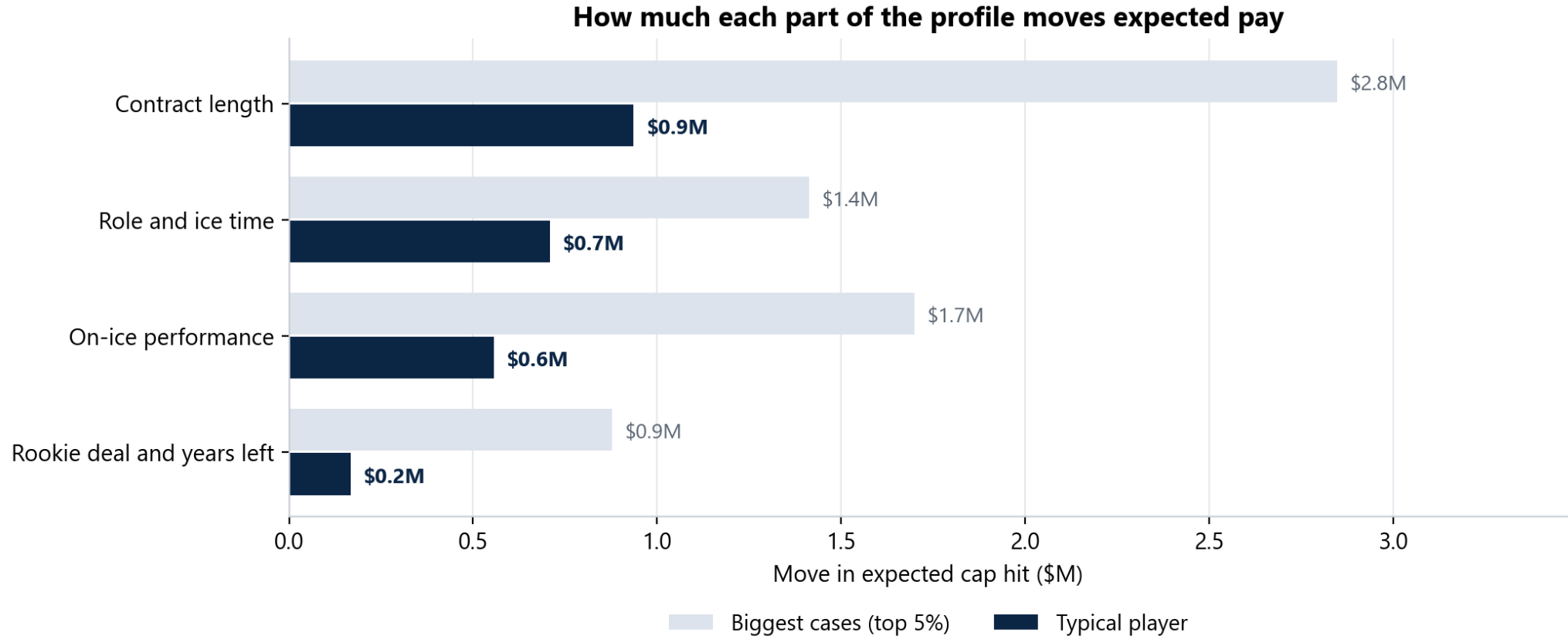
THE MODEL

The biggest gaps in the league this season



Left side: bargains relative to the model. Right side: premiums relative to the model.

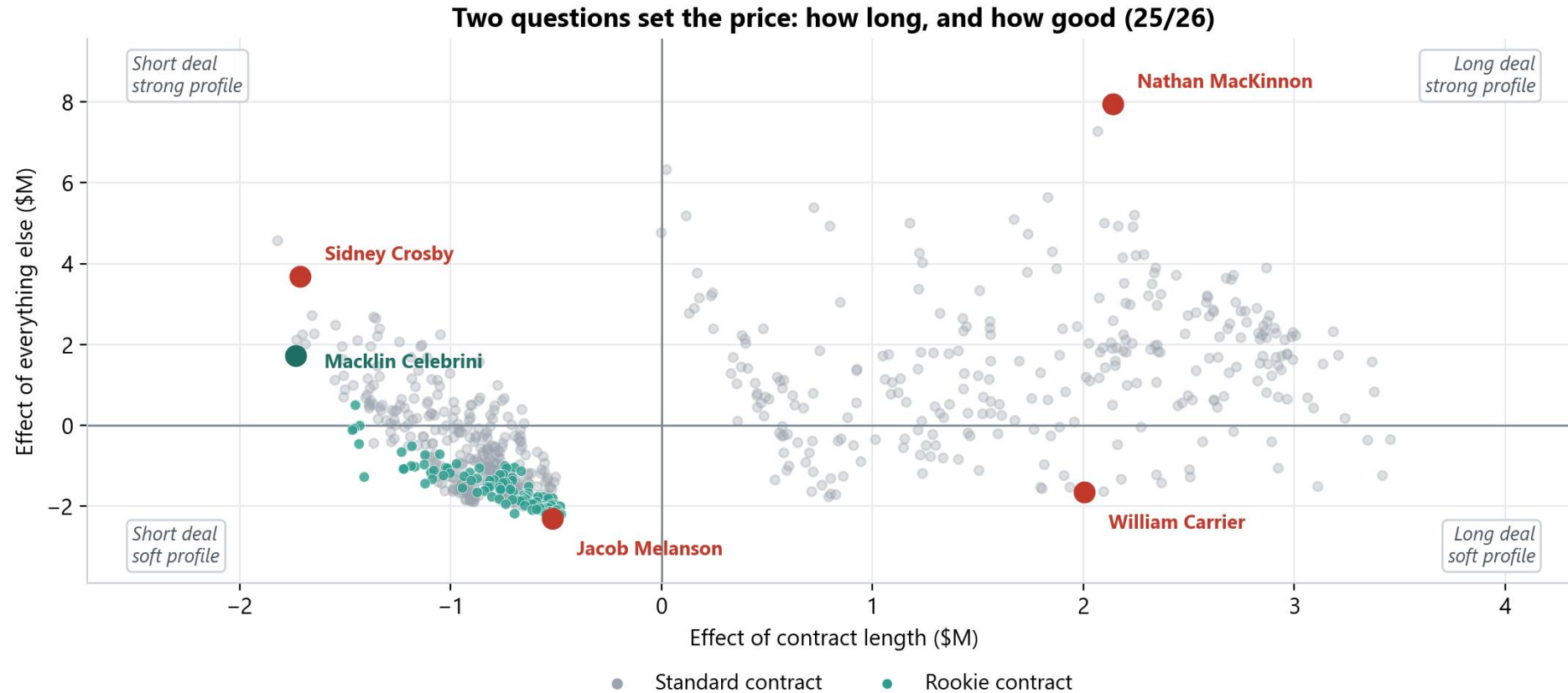
What actually moves expected pay



Contract length sets the price band. Performance and role move the player inside it, and in big cases move more than length.

Four plain groups behind the model: contract length, on-ice performance, role and ice time, rookie deal and years left.

Two questions set the price: how long, and how good

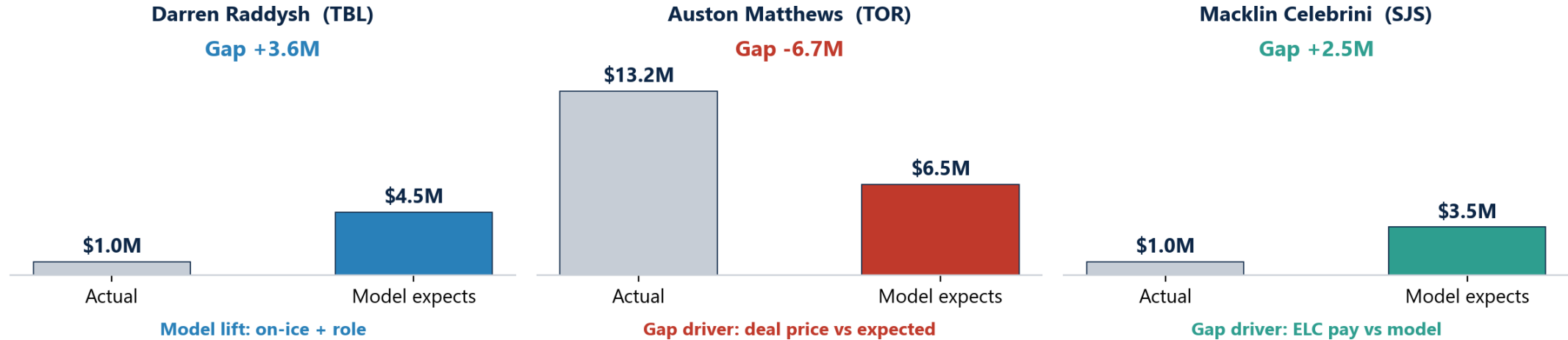


Long term plus a strong season is the expensive corner. Short term plus a soft season is the cheap corner.

Horizontal: what the term of the deal adds or removes. Vertical: everything else about the player. Teal dots are players still on a rookie contract.

THE MODEL

Why a gap appears



PAID BELOW THE MODEL

The model prices the season highly

On-ice play and role lift expected pay. The contract stays cheap, so the gap opens under.

PAID ABOVE THE MODEL

The deal price sits far above expected

Term and price can push a deal above or below the model. Here the package sits far above expected.

STILL ON A ROOKIE DEAL

The rule sets the price, not the market

Entry-level pay stays near the floor. The model still prices the season higher.

A gap can come from the deal, the season, or both.

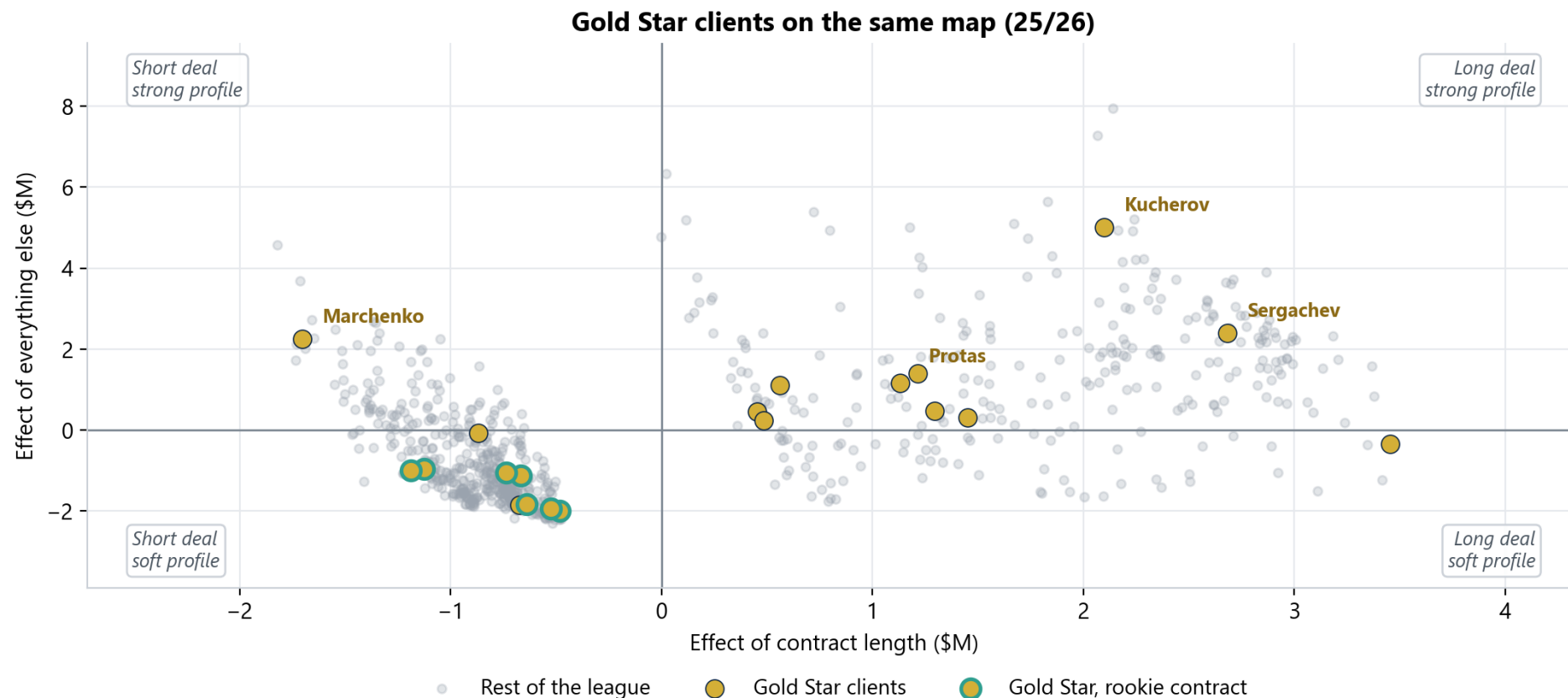
One agency book: Gold Star clients past their rookie deals

Player	Team	Age	Actual	Model expects	Gap	Years left
Aliaksei Protas	WSH	24	\$3.38M	\$5.77M	-2.39M	3
Nikita Kucherov	TBL	32	\$9.50M	\$10.58M	-1.08M	1
Alexander Romanov	NYI	25	\$6.25M	\$6.59M	-0.34M	7
Yegor Sharangovich	CGY	27	\$5.75M	\$6.08M	-0.33M	4
Ivan Barbashev	VGK	29	\$5.00M	\$5.24M	-0.24M	2
Nikita Zadorov	BOS	30	\$5.00M	\$5.24M	-0.24M	4
Kirill Marchenko	CBJ	25	\$3.85M	\$4.01M	-0.16M	1
Mikhail Sergachev	UTA	27	\$8.50M	\$8.54M	-0.04M	5
Evander Kane	VAN	34	\$5.12M	\$5.14M	-0.02M	0
Martin Pospisil	CGY	25	\$1.00M	\$0.94M	+0.06M	0
Artem Zub	OTT	29	\$4.60M	\$4.38M	+0.22M	1
Vladislav Namestnikov	WPG	32	\$3.00M	\$2.52M	+0.48M	1
Ilya Mikheyev	CHI	30	\$4.75M	\$4.19M	+0.56M	0

Most Gold Star clients land within about \$1M of expectation. Protas is the one clear bargain, Kucherov a mild one.

Everyone on a standard contract. Players still on a rookie deal come later, because their pay is capped by rule. Goalies are outside this model.

Gold Star clients cluster in the healthy middle



Long or short, most of the book still carries a strong season. The soft-profile corner is mostly rookies still on entry-level deals.

Gold dots are Gold Star clients. Teal edge marks a rookie deal. Grey is the rest of the league.

Compared with the biggest league gaps, Gold Star looks fair



The biggest league gaps sit more than \$3M below what the model expects. Most Gold Star clients stay inside \$1M. Protas is the exception.

Gold names are Gold Star clients. Grey names are the five biggest gaps under the model, standard contracts only.

Rookie contracts need a different lens

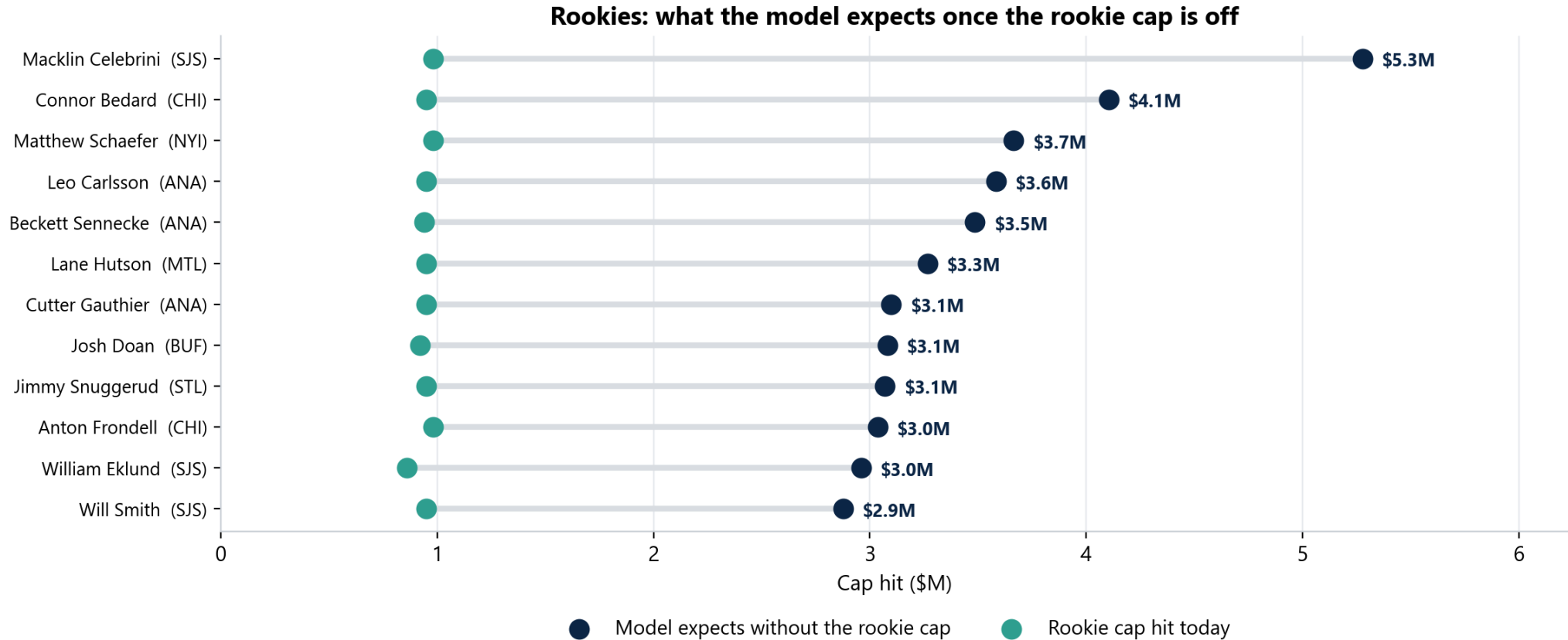
- Rookie pay is capped by the agreement, not by the market
- So a big gap on a rookie deal is not underpayment
- But a signal about the next contract instead
- The model can be run again with that cap switched off
- What comes out is a ranking of who is heading for real money

Two ways to read a rookie

Pay today	CBA capped
Cap switched off	next deal size
Best proof	signed deals

ROOKIES

What the best rookies look worth once the cap comes off

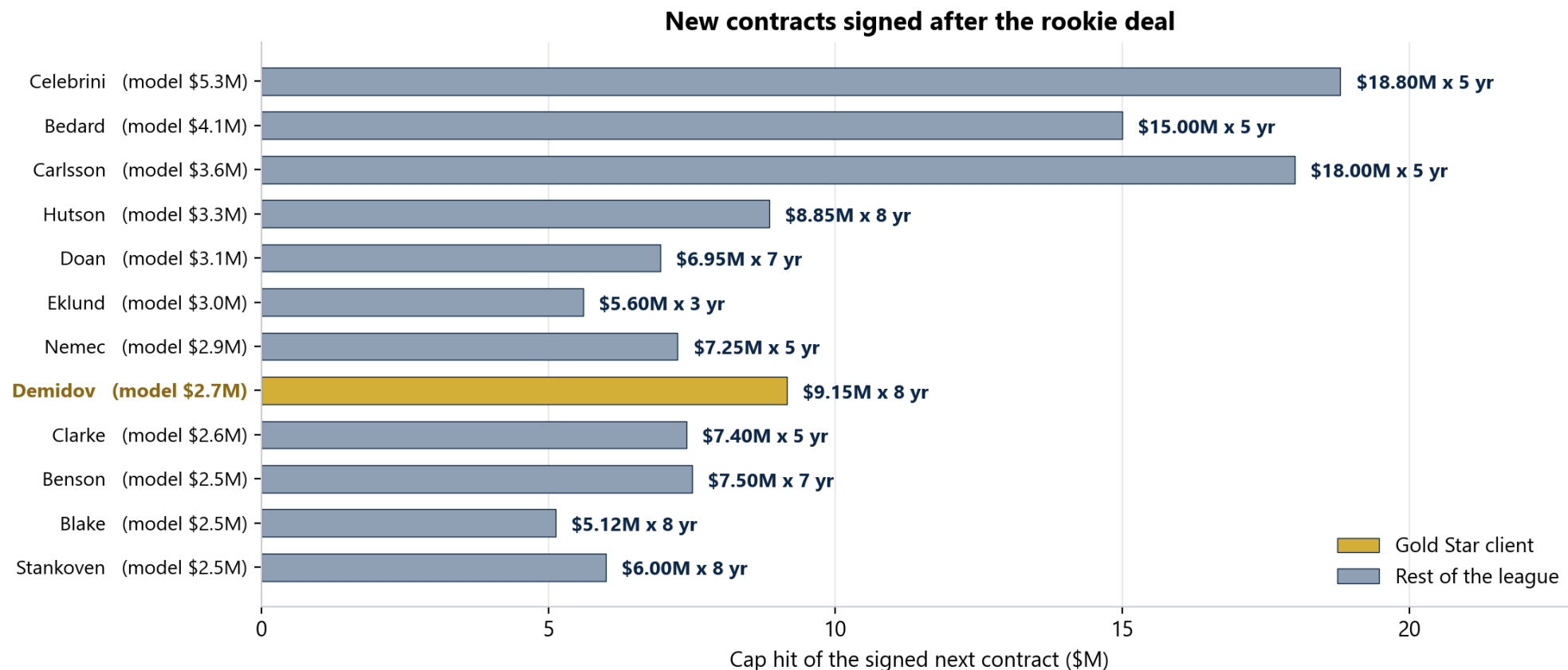


The same season, priced without the rookie cap, moves several names into serious money.

Teal dot is today's rookie cap hit. Navy dot is the model without that cap.

ROOKIES

New contracts already signed for the seasons ahead



These are the next deals after the rookie contract. Players the model ranked highest went on to sign the biggest ones.

As of July 31, 2026. Order comes from the model with the rookie cap switched off. Bars show the signed next contract. Unsigned names stay off the chart.

ROOKIES

Gold Star rookies and where the next money sits

Player	Team	Age	GP	Without rookie cap	Next deal
Artyom Levshunov	CHI	19	68	\$2.77M	not signed yet
Matvei Gridin	CGY	19	37	\$2.76M	not signed yet
Zayne Parekh	CGY	19	37	\$2.66M	not signed yet
Ivan Demidov	MTL	19	82	\$2.65M	8 yr x \$9.15M
Fedor Svechkov	NSH	22	70	\$1.51M	2 yr x \$1.25M
Dmitri Simashev	UTA	20	28	\$1.45M	not signed yet
Ivan Miroshnichenko	WSH	21	13	\$1.38M	2 yr x \$0.93M

Demidov is already locked in long term. Levshunov, Gridin and Parekh are the unsigned names the model points at next.

Bridges for Miroshnichenko and Svechkov are already signed. No projection is implied for unsigned players.

Limits of the model

- It prices one season for one player, not a career
- It does not see injuries, leverage, or a club's cap squeeze
- Long deals of six years or more rest on thin data
- Length tracks pay as association, not as cause
- Goalies need their own model and are not included

WHAT THE MODEL RESTS ON

\$0.77M

Average miss on cap hit

71%

Land inside \$1M of the model

778

Players checked in 25/26

WRAP UP

Things to take away

- The gaps the model finds are large, specific, and checkable
- It narrows the league down to the names that deserve a closer look
- Term sets the band, play and role move the player inside it
- Gold Star's book holds up, Protas may be worth more than his hit
- Rookie gaps point at the next deal, and signings agree

HOW TO READ A GAP

1

Start with the term

Length sets the price band before anything else

2

Read the season

Role, ice time, and production move the player inside it

3

Open the talk

Bring comparable deals, not a verdict

Thank you

Valentin Shepelev

shv66@bu.edu | 513 764 4257